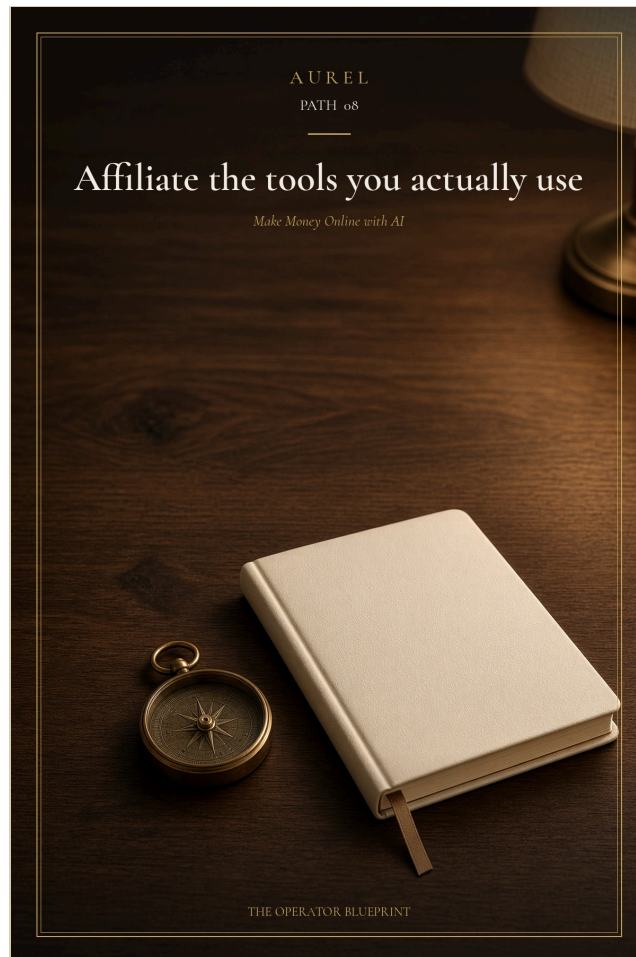




PATH 08

Affiliate the tools you actually use

The review must stand if the link is removed. That is the whole ethic, and the whole conversion trick.

52 minute read · 11,412 words

Who this is for

You already recommend models, hosts, editors, or shops. You can write why, not just drop a URL.

Time to first

14–45 days (cookie + trust lag)

Tools

First sale

One commission from a review a real person used.

Cash window

Varies; treat as a sidecar, not the engine

Leave this alone

Official partner programs, a simple page or newsletter, honest disclosure.

Twenty links in a thread. Tools you have never opened.

How this pays without rotting your name

Affiliate is monetization, not a traffic plan. If nobody reads you, the link does nothing. Short-form and the weekly letter bring the people. This path takes a cut when they buy a tool you would keep using if the commission died.

The review must stand if the link is removed. That is the whole ethic, and the whole conversion trick. Write as if tomorrow a lawyer strips every URL. What remains should still help a tired person decide. If what remains is empty cheer, you wrote an ad.

Definition, in one breath You publish one honest page about one tool in your actual stack. The page names who it is for, setup time, what you tried, what failed, and who should not buy. Disclosure at the top. Link below the reasoning. A date on the page. If they purchase through that link, you may earn a cut. The sentences do not change if the cut vanishes.

You are attaching a cookie to a recommendation you were already making in DMs and in the Tuesday letter. The recommendation came first. The program came second.

What this is not It is not a coupon blog. It is not twenty links in a thread. It is not a tool you opened once on a free weekend. It is not rent money. It is a sidecar on work you already do. Treat commissions as extra. If the engine is affiliate, your name will follow the payout.

It is not hiding the relationship under a hero button. It is not a fake screenshot. It is not a tool you cancelled in March and still rank in June.

Why this works now Buyers already have a model window and a pile of “best of” tabs they do not trust. What they do not have is one page from a person they

already read, dated, with a scar on it, that tells them who should skip the tool. That page outsells a glowing list because it is usable even if they never click.

People in your inbox already ask which model. Every time you answer in a DM, the answer dies in the thread. Write it once. Date it. Disclose it. Put the link under the skip rule. People who need cash on Friday should run a package. People who can wait 14–45 days can let an honest page sit.

How a cookie actually pays you A click is not money. They click your link. The program drops a cookie, or a click ID, that lives 7, 30, or 90 days. If they buy while it is alive, you may get credit. Then the commission sits in pending through the refund window. Then it clears. Then, on a payout calendar, and only if you have crossed a threshold, cash moves. A 30-day cookie plus a 30-day hold plus net-30 is how 14 to 45 days becomes two months.

Most software programs are last-click. If they read you Monday, click a Google ad Thursday, and buy Friday, the ad often gets the sale. You cannot fix that with five tracking scripts. Write the decision. Misses happen. The review still did the job. You pick the tool you still pay for, not the longest timer. The pricing section is the full chain.

Three anti-patterns Anti-pattern one: the farm. Twenty tools, twenty links, zero scars. You will spend the month joining programs and none of the month using the products. One honest page per tool you love. A second tool waits until someone who is not you has used the first page.

Anti-pattern two: the hidden cut. Disclosure in gray eight-point under a hero button. Link above the reasoning. Quiet honesty converts better than a clever fold. If you are ashamed of the relationship, do not join the program.

Anti-pattern three: the engine swap. You pause the letter and the package because a dashboard showed three pending cookies. Pending is not cash.

The deal you keep You keep the stripped-link test. You keep the disclosure at the top. You keep the link below the skip rule. You keep a date on the page. You keep official programs only. You keep tools you still pay for with your

own money. You keep one review until it has been used. You do not keep a farm, a hidden cut, a fake screenshot, or a spending plan built on a maybe.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you already recommend models, hosts, editors, or shops, and you can write why, not just drop a URL. You need a real stack. You need a place to publish one page or one issue. You need the patience for cookie lag.

Fits if You pay for a tool with your own money. You have told a friend why you kept it. You can name something that broke. You will put a disclosure at the top. You already have, or are building, a letter or a simple page where a review can live for a year. You can wait 14–45 days. You will not quit the package because a cookie might convert.

Skip if You do not use anything you would recommend with the link ripped out. You want cash this week — cookies take 14–45 days, and some programs pay later than that. You like roundups of tools you have never opened. You will not update a page when the price changes.

Skip it if you have no readers yet. Start the letter or the front door first. Affiliate does not create attention. It rides it.

Skip it if you freeze at writing “I may earn a cut” in the first screen. Skip it if you need this to be the engine. Do not schedule rent on a surprise.

The honest middle Most people who stall here already recommend a tool in DMs and think a page is a media company. It is not. One page. One tool. One disclosure. One date. The first review is the one you have been typing into chat for six months.

You need two official accounts for tools you already pay for, one written page, and six people who asked last month. Week two will feel quiet. Quiet is normal. Keep sending the letter. Check the partner dashboard once a week, not once an hour.

Skills and time Skills: write a decision, not a brochure. Name a failure without inventing one. Put a disclosure where a tired person will see it. Read the partner rules. Count cash after it clears.

Time: hours 1–8 on programs and rules. Hours 9–24 on the review. Hours 25–72 on publish and six notes. Then 14–45 days of lag. Budget: \$0 extra if you already pay for the tool and join the official program.

Two-minute self-test Answer these out loud.

Which tool do you still pay for with your own money, and would you keep paying if the program vanished tomorrow?

Can you name, in one sentence, who should not buy it?

What actually failed the first week you used it?

What would you use instead if this tool disappeared tomorrow?

Where will the page live for a year — a letter, a simple page, or both?

Who are six people who asked you about this tool last month, that you can message once?

If you have the tool, the skip rule, the scar, the alternative, a place to publish, and six names, write the page this morning. If you cannot name a failure, use the tool another week. If you have no one to tell, this path is a forest. Build the letter first.

The buyer on the other side A tired person who already has three best-of tabs open and trusts none of them. They asked you which tool because they have a Tuesday job, not because they collect software. They will judge you on whether the skip rule is real, whether setup time is in minutes, and whether you named the ugly part. They will ignore a hero button.

They are allowed to skip. Skip is a success. They are allowed to buy through a different link. The review still did the job.

The offer, named in one sentence

You are not selling the tool. You are publishing a review a real person can use, with a link underneath for the ones who decide to buy. Fill this before you write the page:

I use [tool] for [job]. Here is who it is for, how long setup took, what failed, who should not buy, and what I would use instead. If you purchase through this link I may earn a cut. The review is the same either way.

That sentence is the page, the DM, and the letter close. If you cannot fill the brackets without a paragraph, you do not know the tool yet. Use it another week. Do not join the program to soothe the blank. The buyer is a person with a Tuesday problem, not anyone using AI. If the buyer is anyone, you will write a glowing list.

What to write in the review Five parts. If one is empty, you are not ready to publish.

Setup. Minutes, not a feature table. What you actually did the first evening. Forty minutes is a number a tired person can use. Easy and intuitive is a brochure.

Who it is for. The Tuesday job plus a constraint. People who write the same kind of client note every week. Not anyone who wants to save time.

Who should skip. A real person, named by behavior. Anyone who will paste the raw output to a client. Not people who do not like quality tools. If you cannot name a skip, you have a brochure.

The ugly part. What failed. Asking it to sound more human made it sound like a brochure. Setup that took three hours counts. A feature you turned off counts. Nothing failed is a glowing list in one sentence.

The alternative. What you used before, or what you would use if this vanished tomorrow. Name it in words. Do not slap a second affiliate link on it unless you actually pay for that one too. Without an alternative, the page is a funnel with a scar pasted on.

Write those five on paper before you open a landing-page theme.

Five example sentences that work I use this model for client follow-up drafts. It is for people who write the same kind of note every week. Setup took forty

minutes. Asking it to “sound more human” failed. Do not buy it if you will paste raw output to a client. If you purchase through this link I may earn a cut.

I use this host for a Tuesday letter. It is for operators who want a list they own. Setup took a Sunday. The tagging UI annoyed me for a month. Skip it if you need a daily blast machine.

I use this editor for cutting ums out of walkthroughs. It is for people who already record. The first export was worse than the take. I stayed because the second export was the take. Skip it if you want a full course studio.

I use this form tool for kickoff questions after a deposit. Logic jumps broke on my third form. I stayed for the export. Skip it if you need a full CRM.

The job is in the sentence. The scar is in the sentence. The skip is in the sentence. The cut is in the sentence.

What they get They get a decision. They get setup time in minutes, not a feature table. They get a failure they can avoid. They get a skip rule they can use to walk away. They get a date so they know when you last looked. They get a disclosure they do not have to hunt for. They get a link they can ignore. If they finish the page and choose a competitor, you still did the job.

What they do not get They do not get a roundup of five tools you kind of used. They do not get a coupon code you invented. They do not get a guarantee the program bans. They do not get you in their setup call. They do not get a comparison spreadsheet of fifty rows.

Packaging One tool, one page. If you use two things — a model and a host — that is two pages, written weeks apart if you need the time, each with its own disclosure and its own date. Do not staple them into a stack guide in week one.

The letter is allowed to carry the review. A YouTube walkthrough is allowed to carry it, with the disclosure spoken in the first 15 seconds and written in the first lines of the description. A blog post is allowed to be the page. A Google Doc that forwards is enough. Working beats a microsite. Official is a date, a scar, and a sentence about the cut.

What ‘done’ looks like

Done is one commission from a review a real person used. Not a screenshot of a dashboard full of pending cookies. A human told you they bought because the page named the thing that was stuck, or you saw a conversion you can tie to that URL. Pending is a maybe. Cleared is done for v1.

Definition of done The page exists. The disclosure is at the top in words you would want from a friend. The structure is complete: who it is for, setup time, what you tried, what failed, who should not buy. The link sits below the reasoning. The screenshot is yours, or there is no screenshot because the program bans it. The date is a month and a year. You joined an official program and read the rules. You shared the page once with people who already asked. A commission cleared, or a stranger told you they used the page to decide.

The fairness test Would you forward this page to a friend who asked in good faith, even if they used a different link and you earned nothing? If you would be embarrassed, it is an ad. Fair also means the skip rule is real — you named a person who should not buy, and you meant it. Fair means the failure is a thing that happened, not a fake humility paragraph. Fair means if they never click, they still leave with a decision. Fair means you would keep paying for the tool if the program vanished tomorrow. If you would cancel the tool when the affiliate account dies, the page is a trap. Take it down.

The bar for the page Strip every URL. Read it. A tired person can still decide. The disclosure is in the first screen, not the footer. Setup is in minutes. The ugly part happened. The skip names a behavior. The alternative is a real option, not a threat. Month and year. One primary link, after the skip rule. Your dashboard if allowed, names blurred. No banned claims. No income promise. If the page only works with the button in it, you wrote an ad with extra paragraphs.

The bar for the money You can explain, in one sentence, how this program pays: bounty or percent, cookie length, hold, payout calendar. You count cleared, not pending, not clicks. You have not spent a pending cookie. You have not paused the letter. First cleared commission, or a stranger who used the page to decide, is the milestone. A dashboard of maybes is not.

Technical done - Official partner account, rules read, trademark notes in a doc - Disclosure at the top, not under a fold of adjectives - Who it is for, setup time, what you tried, what failed, who should not buy - Link below the skip rule. Once, maybe twice. Not in every sentence - Your own stack. Screenshot your own dashboard if the program allows it. No fake screenshots - A date. Month and year. Updated when pricing or the product changes - Shared once with people who already asked. Letter issue optional, still one link - Commissions counted when they clear, not when they pend

Not-done-yet list You are not done if the disclosure is in the footer, you have twenty pending cookies and zero sentences a friend could use, you have a best-50 farm, you have not sent the page to the six people who asked last month, or the price moved and your page still shows last year's number. Ship one honest page. Then wait. Then update. Then, maybe, tool two.

How the money actually shows up

You do not set the product price. The program does. Your job is to pick tools you already use, join official partner programs, and accept that cash is lumpy. Treat every number you have not cleared as a screenshot, not a salary. Two operators on the same program will not earn the same. Do not build a spending plan on someone else's screenshot.

How cookies and commission actually pay Four clocks, not one.

Clock one is the click. They hit your link. The program sets a cookie or a click ID. No click, no cookie. If they type the vendor's name into search and buy from an ad, you will not see it. That

is fine.

Clock two is the cookie window. Typical software: 7, 30, or 90 days. If they buy inside that window, you may get credit. If they buy on day 31 of a 30-day cookie, you get nothing. Last-click usually wins. Your Monday cookie can be overwritten by Thursday's ad.

Clock three is the hold. The commission is pending while the customer can still refund. Thirty days is common. Recurring cuts can be clawed back if they cancel inside a window named in the terms. Pending is a maybe. It is not a number you spend.

Clock four is payout. Net-30 or net-45 after the commission clears is common. Many programs also have a threshold: \$25, \$50, \$100. Under the line, nothing moves. Some pay PayPal. Some pay a bank. Some want a tax form before the first dollar. Until it clears and pays, it is a screenshot.

Clicks are vanity. Pending is a maybe. Cleared is a row in a sheet. Paid is cash. Count the last two.

30-day vs 90-day A 30-day cookie is the default on a lot of monthly seats. It is enough if your reader already wanted the tool and used your page to decide this month. It is tight if they are comparing three hosts for an annual plan. Riley's model program was 30 days. The people who converted had already asked.

A 90-day cookie covers more of the comparison. Annual plans, seats that need a team yes, tools people trial and forget. It is not a reason to pick a tool you do not use. A long cookie on a product you opened once is still a farm with better math.

A 7-day cookie means they buy this week or you miss. You still write the page. You do not spam a reminder on day 6 so the cookie lives.

Read yours. Write the number in the notes doc next to banned claims. Guessing is how you invent a 90-day story on a 7-day program.

Ranges you will actually see Bounty programs: a flat \$20–\$100 when a trial converts to paid. Common on monthly seats. One conversion is lunch, not rent.

Percent of first invoice: 20–40 percent of a month or a year. A \$20 monthly plan at 30 percent is \$6. A \$192 annual host plan at 40 percent is about \$77.

Recurring: some programs pay a cut every month the customer stays. Recurring can be clawed back if they refund. Do not spend a recurring maybe. Count it after it clears, twice.

High advertised cuts: 50 percent and up often pay on a plan your reader will not buy, or they pay on month one and vanish. Read the terms.

When cash hits the account A conversion in week 3 can clear in week 5 and pay in week 7. That is a healthy program, not a broken one. If you need rent on Friday, this is the wrong path for Friday. Run a package. Let this ride along.

Thresholds delay small bounties. Two \$20 bounties on a \$50 threshold sit until a third shows up. Read that line. Tax forms delay the first payout if you skipped them in week 1. Do the form the day you are approved.

Self-purchases and buying your own tool through your link are how people get banned. Do not test the cookie by checking out as yourself.

Worked dollars Riley's model program paid a \$20 bounty when a trial converted to the \$20 monthly plan. No recurring. Cookie: 30 days. Payout: net-30 after conversion. Week 1: page live, six notes, one letter close. About four hours, on a tool Riley already paid \$20 to use. Week 3: one conversion pending. Week 5: \$20 cleared. Week 7: \$40 cleared. Same two months, the Tuesday letter sold two \$19 files (\$38). Affiliate paid \$40. The letter and the package paid the month.

A later annual host conversion at 40 percent of \$192 is about \$77. That is a good month for this path. Do not build a spending plan on a number you saw in someone else's screenshot. Count commissions after they clear.

What you never do for a higher cut You never hide the disclosure. You never pretend you still use a tool you cancelled. You never stuff every paragraph with links. You never invent a claim the

program bans. You never switch the recommended plan because a higher tier pays more and your reader does not need it.

The first 72 hours

You are not launching a media company. You are joining two programs and writing one review. Then you wait on purpose.

Day 1 morning (hours 1–4): pick the tool and read the rules Open the stack you actually pay for. Circle two tools you would keep if every affiliate account died tomorrow. A model you draft with. A host you send with.

Join two official partner programs from the vendor's own site. Read the trademark rules and the disclosure rules. Note banned claims, screenshots, cookie length, and payout lag. If a program wants you to hide the relationship, skip it.

Day 1 afternoon (hours 5–8): structure on paper, no pitch yet On paper, not in a landing-page builder: who it is for. Setup time in minutes. What you tried. What failed. Who should not buy. If a section is empty, you do not know the tool yet. Use it another week. A setup that took three hours counts. A feature you turned off counts.

Pick the job the tool actually does for you. Riley's job was client follow-up drafts, not "AI."

Day 1 night (hours 9–12): write the review Disclosure at the top. Then who, setup, tried, failed, skip. Date it with the month and the year. Put the link after the skip rule. Once. Screenshot your own dashboard if allowed, names blurred. If screenshots are banned, use words.

Write as if the URL will be stripped tomorrow. Read it out loud. If it collapses into "it is great, click here," you wrote an ad. Cut the adjectives. Keep the scar.

Day 2 (hours 13–36): edit, publish, six names In the morning, reread cold. Add the skip rule if you went soft overnight. Publish on a simple page or

as a letter issue. Ugly is allowed. A heading, the date, the body, the link.

Write six names. People who asked you about that tool last month. Not a cold list. Six is an hour of messages, not a campaign. Do not send a blast.

Day 3 (hours 37–72): send once, then stop Send the six notes. If you have a Tuesday letter this week, the issue can carry the story — the failure, then the page — with the disclosure at the top of that issue. Share it once. Then wait.

If nobody of the six replies, you still have a page. Do not rebuild the offer. Do not join four more programs. Go back to the letter and the package. Check the partner dashboard on Day 10, not Day 3 at midnight.

What you do not do in the first 72 hours You do not join a third program. You do not cloak the URL. You do not test the cookie by buying the tool through your own link. You do not pin a best tool comment under strangers. You do not add a related prompt library you opened once. You do not schedule a week of reminder emails so the 30-day cookie stays warm. You do not pause the letter. Seventy-two hours. Then you wait on purpose.

The path, step by step

Twelve steps. One tool until the page is good. If you have two reviews in week one, you have a farm.

Step 1. Only tools in your actual stack Open the bill you already pay. If you would cancel the tool when the affiliate account dies, it does not belong on the page. Screenshot your own dashboard if allowed. Use it until you can fill the failure section without inventing.

Step 2. Join official programs only Join from the vendor's own site. No cloaks you do not understand. Read trademark, disclosure,

banned claims, cookie length, and payout schedule. If the program wants you to hide the relationship, walk out. Two programs to start.

Step 3. Pick one tool for review one A model you draft with, or a host you send with. Not both in one URL soup. Pick the one people already ask you about. Riley picked the model because the inbox kept asking. The host waited.

Step 4. Write the five parts on paper before the pitch Setup in minutes. Who it is for. Who should skip. The ugly part. The alternative. If a section is empty, you do not know the tool yet. Use it another week. Do not open a landing-page theme until those five lines exist. The alternative does not get a second affiliate link unless you actually pay for that tool too.

Step 5. Disclose at the top, in plain English Quiet honesty converts better than a hidden link. Use the FTC-style line in the copy section. I use this. If you buy through this link I may earn a cut. The review is the same either way. Do not bury it under a fold of adjectives. Do not put it in gray eight-point. Do not save it for the footer. Required is the first screen. On video, say it in the first 15 seconds and write it in the first lines of the description.

Step 6. Put the link below the skip rule After the skip rule is a good place. Once, maybe twice if there is a cheaper plan you actually think they should consider. Not in every sentence. Not in the headline. Not above the scar. People bounce when the first object they hit is a button. They stay when the first object is a decision.

Step 7. Date the page and use your own stack Month and year. A dated review is a trust machine. Updated without a date is a trick people know. When the vendor moves a price or a plan name, change the paragraph and the date in the same sitting. Screenshot your own login if allowed, names blurred. Never a fake.

Step 8. Publish on a simple page or in the letter The letter is allowed to carry the review. The page is allowed to be ugly. A Doc, a Notion page, a single site page, one issue, a blog post. Working beats a microsite. You need a URL you can paste to the six people who asked, with a disclosure they do not have to hunt for.

Step 9. Share once where people already asked Last month's DMs. The group you actually help. The letter they already open. Not a spray of best tool comments under strangers. Once. Then stop. Reminders train people to ignore you. Six personal notes is a week-one job.

Step 10. Count commissions when they clear, not clicks Pending is a maybe. Clicks are vanity. Cleared is a row in a sheet. Do not screenshot a dashboard of pendings and call it a launch. Learn this program's four clocks: click, cookie window, hold, payout. Check the dashboard once a week. Log out of the partner site on your phone.

Step 11. Update, recover, or drop When the price or the product changes, change the paragraph and the date in the same sitting. If you recommended junk, take the link down the same day, date the correction, and tell the people you sent it to. If you cancelled the tool, still-pay is no: link down this week. If the program starts asking you to hide the relationship, walk out. Leaving a rotting page up is how the name follows a payout you no longer believe.

Step 12. Add tool two only after the first page has been used Someone who is not you used it. You updated it once. Then one more tool from the stack. Still not fifty. Still not a roundup. Two honest pages a year beats twenty neglected URLs. Treat commissions as a sidecar until the list is real. Do not pause the letter. Do not pause the package. Do not build a best-50 farm while you wait. The sidecar does not get to drive.

Worked example: Riley's one honest review

Riley drafts client follow-ups in a paid model and sends a Tuesday letter from a paid host. People in the inbox kept asking which model. Riley did not drop a link in a reply. Riley wrote one page. This is a seven-week story with dollars, a shipped page, a mistake, a recovery, a stranger conversion, and a later decision not to farm.

The tool was already in the stack. Riley paid \$20 a month with a personal card and would have kept paying if every partner account died. That still-pay test is why this page was allowed to exist. The host program was joined the same Monday and then left unpublished. Two accounts. One page.

What Riley wrote Who: people who write the same kind of client note every week and are tired of restating the voice.
Not for people who need a model to invent a business.

Setup: forty minutes to a project with instructions, three good examples, and a never-do-this list. Riley said the first evening was messy. That line mattered more than a feature table.

The ugly part: asking it to sound more human, which made it sound like a brochure. The recap emails were the win. The joke post was embarrassing and got cut. The fix was pasting two real emails and saying match these, do not improve my personality.

Who should not buy: anyone who will paste the raw output to a client. Riley says that twice. The model drafts. The human sends.

The alternative: a swipe file of the last ten emails Riley actually sent, plus a timer. If the model vanished tomorrow, Riley would not open a different chatbot the same night. That sentence is why a careful person trusted the rest.

The disclosure, on top: I use this model for drafts. If you buy through this link I may earn a cut. The review is the same either way. I would keep paying for it if the program vanished tomorrow. Updated March.

The link sits after the skip rule. One link. No top 10 models. No fake dashboard. Riley's own project list, names blurred, because the program allows it.

Week 1 calendar Monday: official partner account, rules read. Cookie 30 days. Bounty \$20 on trial-to-paid. No recurring. Hold until conversion. Payout net-30. Threshold \$25. Banned-claims list in a doc. Review written that night.

Tuesday: six notes to people who had asked last month. Tuesday letter carried the joke-post failure, then the page, disclosure at the top of the issue. Personal notes. No blast. The dashboard was not open on the phone.

The six notes (Tuesday) Riley sent the page once to six people who had asked last month, and once in the Tuesday letter, below a story about the joke post that failed. Personal notes. No blast.

The mistake On Thursday Riley added a second link, to a “related” prompt library Riley had opened once on a free weekend, because the page looked thin. A reader replied: “I thought you used this weekly. The second link feels like a list.” Riley had stuffed the page to soothe loneliness. The reader was right.

The recovery Riley pulled the second link the same night. Left the model page as one tool, one scar, one skip. Sent a note to the reader: You were right. I took the extra link off. The review is the model I actually pay for. The reader stayed. Riley put one tool per page at the top of the notes.

If the prompt library had shipped, that would have been recommending junk. Recovery is the same motion, louder: link down the same day, dated note at the top, message to anyone you sent it to, no replacement tool that week to make up the money. Count on the still-pay test before the second URL exists.

What happened with dollars Week 3: one conversion pending on the \$20 monthly plan. The program paid a \$20 bounty, no recurring, 30-day cookie, net-30 payout, \$25 threshold. Riley did not spend it. Clicks that week were a handful. Clicks are not commissions.

Week 5: \$20 cleared. A second conversion the same week, another \$20 pending. Together they crossed the \$25 threshold. A third person wrote to say they skipped the tool, which Riley counts

as the page working. Skip is a success.

Week 7: \$40 cleared and paid. Two months, \$40 from the sidecar. Same window, the letter sold two \$19 files (\$38) and Riley still ran the package path as the engine. Affiliate paid lunch.

A stranger converted in week 6 from the letter archive, not from the six notes. Same \$20 bounty, 30-day cookie still valid from a click in week 5. That is cookie lag, not a traffic plan. Riley did not add a roundup to chase more strangers.

After, the update, and tool two Month 2, the host changed a plan name. Riley still had not published the host review. Riley updated the model page date and one paragraph about a new job: follow-ups for a bookkeeper referral, same match these emails trick. Still one tool.

The host review waited until someone who was not Riley had used the first page, and until Riley had updated it once. Tool two got a calendar date, not a panic. No reminder week. No did you buy. One dashboard look a week.

Riley never made the sidecar the engine. That is the part to copy. The pulled second link is the lesson.

Copy you can paste

Keep the disclosure boring. Boring is trustworthy. Fill the brackets. Do not add hype.

FTC-style disclosure in plain English Short, first screen:

I use this. If you buy through this link I may earn a cut. The review is the same either way.

That is the honesty a tired person can hear. You have a material connection: you may get paid if they buy. You say so in the same place as the recommendation, in words a normal person understands. Not a footer. Not a hover.

Longer, if the program or the law you are under wants more:

I am in the [program] partner program. I pay for [tool] with my own money and use it for [job]. If you buy through this link I may earn a commission. I do not get paid to hide problems. I would keep paying for this if the program vanished tomorrow. Last updated [month year].

Spoken, first 15 seconds of a video:

I use this tool for [job]. Some links in the description may earn me a commission if you buy. The review does not change if you never click.

Put the same sentences in the description, first lines, before the tags. A spoken line with a buried description is half a disclosure.

Page title and hero Title: I use [tool] for [job]
— who it is for, what failed, who should skip it.

Hero: I use [tool] for [job]. Setup took [minutes]. Here is who it is for, what broke, who should not buy, and what I would use instead. If you purchase through this link I may earn a cut. The sentences do not change if you never click.

Newsletter issue Put the disclosure in the first screen of the issue, not after a story they have to scroll. Then tell the failure. Then point.

I drafted this issue in [tool]. If you want the review, it is here: who it is for, setup time, what failed, who should skip. I may earn a cut if you buy through the link. The review is the same either way. If you want next Tuesday, it still arrives with no click required.

Do not make the whole issue a pitch. One idea, one story, one ask. The ask is the page, once.

YouTube description First lines, before anything else:

I use [tool] for [job]. Links below may earn me a commission if you buy. I pay for this with my own money. The review is the same if you never click. Updated [month year].

Then the link, once. Then the skip rule in one sentence. Do not lead with twenty URLs. Say the disclosure on camera in the first 15 seconds as well.

Blog open and close Open: I use [tool] for [job]. If you buy through the link in this post I may earn a cut. I would keep paying for it if the program vanished. Setup took [minutes]. Here is who it is for, what failed, who should skip, and what I would use instead. Updated [month year].

Close: If your job matches, the link is here. If it does not, keep the skip rule. I will take the link down if I stop using the tool. One primary link.

The six personal notes Subject: the page I kept meaning to send

You asked me about [tool] last month. I wrote the page I wanted to send you: setup time, what broke, who should not buy. I may earn a cut if you buy through the link. The review is the same either way. Here: [url]. If it is not useful, ignore this.

When they skip: Skip is a valid ending. That is what the page is for. If you want a different job solved, tell me the Tuesday problem. I will not invent a link.

When they ask which tool: I use [tool] for [job]. I wrote the page instead of a chat essay. Disclosure at the top. Skip rule before the link. Here: [url]. If your job is different, the skip rule is the part to read first.

I do not use [tool], so I will not review it. I can tell you what I do use for [job], with the same disclosure I would want from you. I will not add a link I cannot stand behind.

Recovery if you recommended junk Subject: I was wrong about [tool]

I told you [tool] was worth a look. I no longer stand behind that. Here is what broke: [ugly part I missed or that showed up after]. I have taken the link off the page. Do not buy it on my say-so. If you already bought and you want help picking a way out, reply. I will not point you at a replacement cookie this week.

On the page, dated, at the top: Updated [month year]: I no longer recommend this. [What broke.] The link is gone.

When you drop a program Updated [month year]: I cancelled [tool] / I will not hide this relationship / the product changed enough that the old review is a trap.

Link removed. If you landed here from an old note, do not buy through me. Here is the alternative I actually use, with no link until I write that page: [name].

What not to write Best AI tool of the year. Twenty links in a thread. I made \$12,000 in a weekend. Claims the program bans. A disclosure in gray eight-point under a hero button. Nothing failed, it is perfect. Updated with no month. Official partner of the year when you are not. A second tool stuffed in because the page looked lonely. Buy before midnight so my cookie does not expire. Any sentence you would not say to a friend after dinner.

Week-by-week

This path is slow on purpose. Plan the wait so you do not sabotage it with a farm. Four weeks. Cash may arrive in weeks 3–6. That is the cookie.

Week 1, day by day Monday: join two official programs you already use. Read the rules. Pick one tool. Structure on paper: who, setup, tried, failed, skip.

Tuesday: write the review. Disclosure on top. Link below the skip rule. Date it. Publish.

Wednesday: list six names who asked last month. Send the first three notes. Personal. No blast.

Thursday: send the other three. If you have a letter this week, the issue can carry the failure story, then the page, disclosure at the top of the issue.

Friday: reread the page cold. Is the skip rule visible. Is the disclosure in the first screen. Is there exactly one primary link. Fix those three. Do not add tool two.

Saturday: off, or one paragraph in the notes: which program, which rules, where the link lives.

Sunday: rest.

Week 2, day by day Monday: do the other path. Letter, package, file. Not a second review. Tuesday: if the letter goes out, one mention max, below a real story. Same disclosure. Wednesday: check the partner dashboard once. Do

not panic at zero. Thursday: send nothing extra. Friday: if a reader replies with a skip, thank them. If a reader says this sounds like an ad, cut adjectives the same day. Saturday: notes toward the next issue of the letter. Sunday: off.

Week 3 Cookie and trust lag live here. Keep sending the letter. Keep the package. Check the dashboard once. If a conversion pends, do not spend it. If week 3 is silent, do not join four more programs. Silent is the default.

Week 4 Count: reviews published that would stand with the link removed (target: one). Notes sent (six to ten). Clicks if shown. Commissions that cleared, not pending. First cleared one is the milestone, and it may not have happened yet.

If you have clicks and no commissions, read the review again. Often the link is above the reasoning, or you recommended a plan nobody in your audience needs. Fix the page. Do not add a roundup.

Month 2 Update the review if price, product, or your use changed. If nothing changed, add one paragraph about a new job you actually ran. Change the date only if you truly looked. Fake updated is a glowing list with a calendar.

Then, and only then, consider tool two: someone who is not you used page one, and you updated it once. Treat commissions as a sidecar until the list is real.

If the month is quiet Quiet is not a prompt to farm. Ask whether you wrote to people who had the Tuesday problem, or to a cold list. Ask whether the skip rule is real. Ask whether the disclosure is in the first screen. Fix the page. Send six new names who actually asked. Do not join a high-paying program for a tool you have not opened. Do not pause the letter. The sidecar waits. The engine works.

The quality bar

The stripped-link test is the bar. Remove every URL. Read the page. If a careful person could still decide, you are done. If the page collapses into “it is great, click here,” write it again.

Below the bar Disclosure in the footer. Link in the first sentence. No skip rule. No failure. A screenshot that is not yours. Five tools on one URL. A plan you do not use, recommended because it pays more. Twenty links in a thread. A tool you cancelled still wearing your name.

Above the bar Disclosure in the first screen. Link after the skip rule. A failure that happened. A skip you mean. An alternative. Month and year. One tool. A plan you actually pay for. Shared once with people who asked. You would keep paying if the program vanished tomorrow.

Test 1 — the stripped-link test Copy the page into a doc. Delete every URL. Read it. Can a tired person decide. If not, you wrote an ad with extra paragraphs. Add the scar and the skip. Then put the link back, once, under that.

Test 2 — the friend test Would you forward this to a friend who asked in good faith, even if they used a different link and you earned nothing? If you would be embarrassed, it is an ad. If you flinch, cut the cheer.

Test 3 — the failure and skip tests If you cannot name something that broke, you have not used it long enough, or you are hiding. Setup time that was worse than the marketing page counts. A feature you turned off counts. Nothing failed is a glowing list in one sentence. Empty failure section: do not publish. Name who should not buy. Riley's do not paste raw output to a client is a skip rule. A review with no skip is a brochure.

Test 4 — the disclosure placement test Open the page on a phone. Without scrolling, can you read that you may earn a cut. If you have to hunt, it fails. Gray eight-point fails. Footer fails. After a

hero button fails. On a video, first 15 seconds plus first lines of the description. If you are ashamed to put it there, do not join the program.

Test 5 — the still-pay test Would you keep paying for this tool if the program vanished tomorrow? If the honest answer is no, take the page down. Pass it every time you update the date. Pass it before you add tool two. Pass it the week you are tempted by a higher cut on a product you do not open.

Test 6 — the screenshot and date tests Your dashboard, if allowed. Never a fake. Never someone else's crop. If screenshots are banned, use words. Blur names. Month and year on the page. When the vendor moves a price or a plan name, the paragraph and the date change in the same sitting. A page dated last year with this year's price is a trap.

What to count

Count slow numbers. This path lies if you watch it daily. Pending is not cash. Clicks are not commissions. Commissions are not a salary.

Count these, ignore those Count: pages that would stand with the link removed. Notes sent to people who asked. Skip replies. Commissions cleared. Amount paid, after clawbacks. Last date you truly looked. Still-pay, yes or no.

Ignore: other people's disclosed income. Rankings of best affiliate offers. How many tools you could join. A 50-tool content calendar. Pending cookies as a scoreboard. Follower counts. Click count as a grade.

If you have clicks and no commissions after 45 days, read the review again. Often the link is above the reasoning or you recommended a plan nobody in your audience needs.

Week 1 - Reviews published that would stand with the link removed. Target: one - Official programs joined and rules read. Target: two accounts, one page

- People who already asked, that you actually sent the page to. Six to ten is a real week 1 - Disclosure in the first screen (yes/no) - Date on the page (yes/no)

Target: page + six notes. A conversion in week 1 is luck, not a system. Zero conversions is normal.

Day 30 - Clicks, if the program shows them, without panicking at a quiet day - Commissions that cleared, not pending. First cleared one is the milestone - Replies that say they skipped. Count those as the page working - Hours spent on a second review (should be zero) - Dashboard checks per week (should be one, not twenty)

A good first month is one honest page in the world, six to ten personal notes, and maybe \$0-\$40 cleared. \$0 cleared on day 30 is still a fine start if the notes went out. \$40 is Riley's two bounties.

Day 90 - One or two pages, each a tool you still pay for - At least one update with a real date change - Commissions counted only when they clear - Letter still sending. Package still selling. Sidecar still a sidecar - A decision: stay at one tool, add tool two, or take a page down because you cancelled the product - Still no best-50 farm

Day 90 cash is lumpy. If you are at zero pages, you joined programs and wrote nothing. If you are at twenty pages, you built a hole.

One-line spreadsheet Date published | tool | notes sent | clicks (if shown) | pending | cleared | amount cleared | last updated | still pay (y/n)

One row per page. Five minutes after a payout email. If still-pay is no, take the link down this week.

How to read a partner dashboard Clicks: people hit the URL. Not a grade. A handful after six notes is normal. Pending: a maybe inside the hold. Do not spend. Approved / cleared: it survived the hold. Row in the sheet. Paid: cash moved, threshold met, calendar ticked.

This is the only number that buys groceries. Reversed / clawed back: they refunded. Subtract it. This is why you do not spend pending.

If the dashboard will not show cookie length, it is in the FAQ you should have read in week 1. Write it on the notes so you stop guessing 90 on a 30.

Objections you will hear

These are the lines. The reply is what you actually send.

“Affiliate is sleazy.” Hidden affiliate is sleazy. A disclosure on top and a review that names failure is how people already recommend tools, with a cookie attached. Reply: “The review stands if you never click. I may earn a cut if you buy through the link. I would keep paying for this if the program vanished tomorrow.”

“I need traffic first.” Yes. This is not a traffic plan. Build the letter or the door. Then the page has somewhere to live. Reply: “I will write the page when I have six people who already asked. Until then I am sending the letter.”

“Programs take too long to approve.” Some do. Use the wait to write the review without the link, then add the URL. Do not apply to twelve programs to soothe the wait. Reply to yourself: “The sentences do not need a cookie to be useful. I will publish the decision and paste the URL when they approve.”

“What if they buy and the cookie misses?” It happens. The review still did the job. Do not add five tracking scripts to squeeze a maybe. Reply: “If the cookie misses I still wanted them to decide well. I will not install a maze to catch a maybe.”

“Can I round up five tools I kind of used?” No. That is the glowing list. One tool you love. Reply: “I review what I pay for. I will not rank tools

I opened once. If you want the one I actually use, here is the page.”

“The commission is small.” It is a sidecar. Small plus honest plus a list that already trusts you beats large plus a name you cannot reuse. Reply: “I do not run this for rent. \$20 cleared is extra. The letter is the engine.”

“Can you hide the disclosure so it converts better?”

No. Reply: “If hiding it converts better, I do not want those clicks. The disclosure stays in the first screen.”

“Will you review this tool I built if we add you to the program?”

Not if you do not use it. Reply: “I only review tools I pay for with my own money and would keep if the program died.”

“Can you put twenty links in a thread for the algorithm?” No. Reply: “One page, one tool, one link under the skip rule. A thread of twenty is a farm.”

“I bought through your link and I hate the tool.” Take it seriously.

Reply: “Tell me what broke. I will update the failure section if I missed it. If I have stopped using it I will take the link down. If I was wrong, you get the junk-recovery note, not a pep talk.”

What this path feeds — and what it needs

Affiliate rides the other paths. It does not replace them. If you treat it as the engine, you will write whatever the payout table wants, and the other paths will smell it.

Upstream — what you need before this path You need a stack you pay for. You need six people who already asked. You need a place the page can live for a year: a letter, a simple page, or both. You need a spine for a disclosure in the first screen. You do not need a review empire or twelve programs.

If you have never shipped a letter or a front door, start there. Affiliate does not create attention. If you have no one to ask, this path is a forest.

Downstream — where a good page goes next A Tuesday issue can tell the story of what failed, then point to the review. A playbook can mention the model you used, with the same disclosure. A package can include here is the tool I draft in; you do not have to buy it. The cut is extra. The trust is the asset.

People who skip the tool still trust the next page. Riley counted the skip email as the page working. That reader will believe review two. When a commission clears, do not add a farm. Add a date-check on the calendar.

What it needs It needs people. Official programs. One page. A stack you still pay for. It needs you to leave twenty-link threads alone. It needs a notes doc with cookie length and banned claims. It needs a still-pay test you will actually fail out loud. It needs the letter and the package to keep running while you wait on a hold.

What it does not need It does not need a coupon extension. It does not need a cloaked URL you cannot explain. It does not need you to pause cash to write a best-50. It does not need a review-site theme. It does not need a 90-day cookie on a tool you do not open. If the letter dies, this path dies with it.

Keep the engine Keep the letter. Keep the package. Let the cookie ride. The Operator Suite is a set of paths that feed each other. This one is a sidecar. Unbolt it and you still have a bike. Unbolt the bike and you have a coupon blog with your name on the header. When a month surprises you, bank it. Do not rebuild the week around it.

Mistakes that rot the name

Each one has a recovery you can do this week.

1. Fake screenshots Recovery this week: delete the image.
Use your dashboard if allowed, names blurred, or use words. If you already published a fake, take it down today.
2. Recommending junk, or a tool you cancelled The page becomes a trap for people who trust you. Recovery this week: still-pay test out loud. If no, remove the link the same day. Date the change. Message anyone you sent it to: I was wrong. Here is what broke. Do not buy it on my say-so. Leave the review up only as I used to, here is why I left, with the cookie gone. Do not collect a commission on a product you will not defend. Do not replace it with a different tool the same week to make up the money. A model will write a brochure if you let it: you still add the scar, the setup time, and the skip, or you do not publish.
3. Stuffing every paragraph with links That is how readers stop reading, and how some programs warn you. Recovery this week: one primary link, after the skip rule. Delete the rest.
4. Forgetting banned claims Income promises, trademark misuse, “official” language you were not given. Recovery this week: search your page for numbers you did not earn and titles you were not given. Cut them today.
5. The farm Twenty links in a thread. A best-50 farm. Recovery this week: unpublish the roundup. Keep one honest page.
6. Building this before you have a place people already look A perfect review in a forest is still a forest. Recovery this week: send the page to six people who asked, or start the letter.
7. Refreshing the dashboard hourly Pending is not cash. Hourly checks train you to sabotage the wait with a farm. Recovery this week: one calendar reminder, weekly. Log out of the partner site on your phone.

8. Recommending the higher plan because it pays more Your reader does not exist to optimize your cut. Recovery this week: recommend the plan you actually use, or the cheaper one you actually think they should start with.

9. Hiding the disclosure, or using a cloak you do not understand Gray eight-point. Footer only. After a hero button. A network that can swap the vendor later. Recovery this week: move the boring sentence to the first screen. Replace any cloaked URL with the official program link. If you cannot join official, you do not review that tool for a cookie.

10. Treating pending as rent, or leaving a rotting program up Then you will write desperate pages when it fails to clear, or you will collect cookies on a product you no longer use. Recovery this week: count cleared only. Put the spending plan back on the package and the file.

When to drop a program: you cancelled the tool. You have not opened it in 90 days. They want the disclosure hidden. They pay you to push a plan you would not buy. The merchant swapped under a network you cannot explain. You were wrong and the product is junk. Any one of those is enough. Link down this week. Sidecar, not engine.

Tools (official, few, used)

Official partner programs, a simple page or newsletter, honest disclosure. That is the stack. Boring on purpose.

Exact stack - Two official partner accounts, joined from the vendor's own site, both for tools you already pay for - One page: Google Doc published, Notion, or a single site page. Ugly is allowed - Or the letter you already send, with the review as an issue - A notes doc: banned claims, cookie length, payout lag, still-pay test - Your own login, for a screenshot if allowed - A one-line spreadsheet: published, notes sent, cleared, last updated

No review-site theme. No 40 comparison tables. No unofficial coupon extension. No cloaker you cannot explain.

Setup order 1. Pick two tools you still pay for. 2. Join both official programs. Read the rules. Write the banned list. 3. Pick one tool for page one. 4. Write who, setup, tried, failed, skip on paper. 5. Disclose at the top. Date it. Link below the skip rule. 6. Publish ugly. 7. Send six notes. 8. Calendar: dashboard once a week. Update check in 90 days.

What not to buy A review-site template. A rank tracker. A cloaking tool. A CRM for twenty programs. A course on affiliate empires. A stock photo of a dashboard that is not yours.

The \$0 path The model or host you already pay for. The official program, free to join. A Google Doc published to the web, or a Notion page, or the newsletter you already send. Mail you already have. You need a URL a tired person can open, with a disclosure they do not have to hunt for.

If you have no letter and no site, the Doc is the page. Send the Doc. Six names and a dated Doc is a start.

Official partner programs Join from the vendor's own site. Two to start, both in your actual stack. Read trademark and disclosure rules before you write a headline. If they want you to hide the relationship, you want out. The letter you already send is enough as a home for the page. Keep the disclosure at the top. Plain sentences. Not a legal poem. Not a tiny footnote.

Leave link-in-bio mazes of twenty tools, unofficial coupon extensions, and any program that asks you to hide the relationship.

Checklist

Tick this before you add a second tool.

Before you join - Tool is in your actual stack; you would keep paying without the program - Still-pay test said out loud: yes - You can name setup minutes, who it is for, who should skip, the ugly part, the alternative - You have six people who already asked, or a letter that already goes out - You are not picking this program for cookie length or advertised cut

Before you publish - Tool is in your actual stack; you would keep paying without the program - Still-pay test said out loud: yes - Official partner account, joined from the vendor's site - Rules read: trademark, disclosure, banned claims, cookie length, payout lag - Banned-claims list in a notes doc - Disclosure written at the top, first screen, not footer - Structure complete: who it is for, setup time, what you tried, what failed, who should not buy - Failure is a thing that happened, not a fake humility paragraph - Skip rule names a real person who should not buy - Link below the reasoning, after the skip rule - One primary link, maybe one cheaper-plan link you actually mean - Screenshot is yours, names blurred, or no screenshot if banned - Date on the page, month and year - No banned claims, no income promise, no fake "official" title - Page would still help if every URL were stripped

First 72 hours - One review, not a roundup - Page published on a Doc, Notion, site, or letter issue - Six people who already asked, named - Six notes sent, once, personal - Letter issue optional, still one link, disclosure at top of issue - No second tool added because the page looked lonely - Dashboard not open on your phone - You did not test the cookie by buying through your own link

When money shows up - Clicks noted without a funeral - Pending left pending - Cleared logged - Clawbacks subtracted - Paid counted only after it hits the account - Letter still sending. Package still selling - No spending plan built on a maybe

When to drop, and ongoing - Update when price or product changes; change the date in the same sitting - 90-day calendar reminder to look again - Commissions

counted when they clear, not when they pend - One dashboard check per week - Sidecar, not the engine; letter and package still running - Still no best-50 page - Tool two waits until someone who is not you used page one, and you updated it once - If you cancelled the tool, you recommended junk, they want the disclosure hidden, or you have not opened it in 90 days, link comes down this week

FAQ

Short answers. Default at the end of each.

Can I join a program for a tool I used once? No. Use it until you can fill setup, skip, ugly, and alternative without inventing. Once is a first date. A review is a relationship. Default: not until you still pay, and you can name a scar.

Do I have to say affiliate in the first line? Say you may earn a cut if they buy through the link, and that the review does not change. That is the honesty. Use the word affiliate if the program or the law you are under wants it. Quiet and early beats clever and late. On video, say it in the first 15 seconds and put it in the first lines of the description. Default: cut named in the first screen.

Newsletter, page, blog, or YouTube? Whichever you already have. Riley did a page and mentioned it in the letter. A blog post can be the page. A YouTube walkthrough can carry the same five parts, with the disclosure spoken and written. Default: one URL, then extras if they already exist.

How many links, and does 30-day vs 90-day change the page? One primary. A second if there is a cheaper plan you actually think they should consider. Cookie length does not change the sentences. Write the number in your notes. Do not pick the tool for the timer. Default: one link, after the skip rule.

What if the program rejects me? Write the review anyway without a link, or pick the second tool you already use. Rejection is not a prompt to join a shady network. If you cannot join official, you do not review that tool for a cookie. Default: sentences first, cookie second. Official only.

Can I use a model to write the review? You can outline. You still have to add the scar: setup time, what failed, who should skip, the alternative. A model will write a glowing list. That is the thing we are not doing. Default: you add the scar or you do not publish.

When do I add a second review, and is this rent? After someone who is not you used the first one, and you have updated it once. Then one more tool from the stack. Still not fifty. Treat it as a sidecar. Some months will surprise you. Do not schedule rent on a surprise. Default: tool two after use plus one update. Package and letter for rent, this for extra.

What if I recommended junk, or they hate the tool? Take the link down the same day. Date the correction. Tell the people you sent it to. Update the failure section if you missed it. Do not talk them into staying so you can keep a cookie. Do not add a replacement cookie that week. If you cancelled the tool, the page may stay as I left, here is why, with the link gone. Default: link down when still-pay is no, or when you were wrong.

The vendor changed pricing, or a commission clawed back Update this week. Change the date. A dated correction builds more trust than a perfect first draft you abandoned. Clawbacks are why you count cleared, twice if you need to, and why you do not spend pending. Default: same sitting, paragraph plus date. Wait until a commission would survive a refund window before you call it cash.

What if nobody of the six replies, or I want to review a free tool? The page can still sit. Ask whether you wrote to people who had the Tuesday problem, or to a cold list. Rewrite so it has a job, a scar, and a skip. Do not add a roundup. A free

tool you love can have a page with no link. Many free tools have no program. The sentences are still a gift to the letter. Default: six new names who actually asked, not twenty new programs. No program required for the sentences. Program required for the cookie.